

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1970-03-06

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

79.1 We have your letter of 14 January 1970 asking questions about the decision-making process of Spiritual Assemblies.

79.2 It is important to realize that the spirit of Bahá'í consultation is very different from that current in the decision-making processes of non-Bahá'í bodies.

79.3 The ideal of Bahá'í consultation is to arrive at a unanimous decision. When this is not possible a vote must be taken. In the words of the beloved Guardian: "... when they are called upon to arrive at a certain decision, they should, after dispassionate, anxious, and cordial consultation, turn to God in prayer, and with earnestness and conviction and courage record their vote and abide by the voice of the majority, which we are told by our Master to be the voice of truth, never to be challenged, and always to be wholeheartedly enforced."

79.4 As soon as a decision is reached it becomes the decision of the whole Assembly, not merely of those members who happened to be among the majority.

79.5 When it is proposed to put a matter to the vote, a member of the Assembly may feel that there are additional facts or views which must be sought before he can make up his mind and intelligently vote on the proposition. He should express this feeling to the Assembly, and it is for the Assembly to decide whether or not further consultation is needed before voting. 12879.6 Whenever it is decided to vote on a proposition all that is required is to ascertain how many of the members are in favor of it; if this is a majority of those present, the motion is carried; if it is a minority, the motion is defeated. Thus the whole question of "abstaining" does not arise in Bahá'í voting. A member who does not vote in favor of a proposition is, in effect, voting against it, even if at that moment he himself feels that he has been unable to make up his mind on the matter.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

80 Commemoration of the Centenary of the Martyrdom of Mírzá Mihdí, the Purest Branch

25 MARCH 1970

To all National Spiritual Assemblies Dear Bahá'í Friends, 80.1 In commemoration of the centenary of the martyrdom of the Purest Branch, which falls on 23 June 1970, we call upon the Bahá'ís of the world to unite in prayer for "the regeneration of the world and the unification of its peoples."

80.2 During those days one hundred years ago Bahá'u'lláh was enduring His imprisonment in the Barracks of 'Akká. Upon the tribulations which weighed Him down was heaped the fatal accident which befell His young son, His companion and amanuensis, Mírzá Mihdí, the Purest Branch, whose dying supplication to his Father was to accept his life "as a ransom for those of His loved ones who yearned for, but were unable to attain, His presence." In a Tablet revealed in that grievous hour Bahá'u'lláh sorrows that "This is the day whereon he

that was created of the light of Bahá has suffered martyrdom, at a time when he lay imprisoned at the hands of his enemies." Yet He makes clear that the youth passing has a far profounder meaning than His acceptance of the simple request, declaring that "Thou art, verily, the trust of God and His treasure in this land. Erelong will God reveal through thee that which He hath desired." In a prayer revealed for His son He proclaims the purpose underlying the tragedy: "I have, O my Lord, offered up that which Thou hast given Me, that Thy servants may be quickened, and all that dwell on earth be united." Thus upon a youth of consummate devotion who demonstrated such beauty of spirit and total dedication was conferred a unique station in the Cause of God. 80.3 In your recalling the bereavement of Bahá'u'lláh upon the loss of His loved son, and honoring a highly significant event in the Faith, we leave it to the discretion of the Assemblies whether they choose to hold special gatherings of prayer. In the Holy Land at the World Center 129on Mount Carmel there will be an observance at the grave of Mírzá Mihdí, at which time his pure example and sacrifice for all mankind will be remembered through the words of his glorious Father.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

80.4 For your background and appreciation of the nature of the martyrdom of the Purest Branch, we refer you to *God Passes By*, pp. 188–89, and to *Bahá'í Holy Places at the World Center*, pp. 60, and 70–74, from which the several quotations above are derived.

81 Ríḍván Message 1970

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]